3.4 Appomattox

Forgiving a sibling or a friend after a fight is hard to do. Generals Grant and Lee had a difficult task in front of them when they met to end the war. Grant wondered: Was it better to forgive former enemies, or punish them further?

MAIN IDEA The Civil War ended with the surrender of the Confederacy at a simple ceremony in Virginia.

SURRENDER AT LAST

By the beginning of 1865, war had nearly completely devastated the South. Sherman continued to march through the Carolinas, burning homes, barns, and crops. Knowing the end was near, Confederate president Jefferson Davis sent his vice president, **Alexander Stephens**, to meet with Lincoln on February 3, 1865. His goal was to negotiate peace and bring the war to an end. Not interested in negotiating, Lincoln demanded that the Confederacy surrender completely. Stephens refused, and the war continued.

Meanwhile, General Lee finally had to abandon his defense of Richmond after the Confederate government fled and Union troops marched in to take over the city. But Lee still had hopes of turning the situation around. He tried to move his forces south in order to join other Confederate forces in North Carolina. Lee's army never reached that goal. Union cavalry surrounded Lee and his troops near the Virginia town of **Appomattox Court House**, halting his progress. Following a brief battle, Lee agreed to surrender.

On April 9, 1865, Lee met Grant in the front room of Wilmer McLean's home in Appomattox Court House. Grant arrived in his muddy field uniform, while Lee wore his full dress uniform. Lee accepted Grant's terms of surrender. All Confederate officers and soldiers were pardoned. They could keep their private property, including their horses, which they would need for spring planting. Confederate officers were also allowed to keep their side arms. Grant made sure that Lee's men, many of whom were starving, would receive Union rations. Grant told his officers: "The war is over. The Rebels are our countrymen again."

The Confederacy had fought with courage and endured almost unimaginable hardships. But courage was not enough to defeat the resources and manpower of the far more powerful industrial North. The Union prevailed.

COSTS OF THE WAR

In dollars and cents, the Union spent more than $3 billion on the war; the Confederacy spent about $1 billion. But these amounts of money for military expenditures barely compared to the massive loss of life. Roughly 620,000 men had died: 360,000 Union soldiers and 260,000 Confederate soldiers, the most American lives lost in any conflict to date.

Two out of every three deaths occurred not from battle, but from disease. The most common diseases in army camps were typhoid fever, smallpox, measles, diarrhea, pneumonia, malaria, and tuberculosis. Army surgeons relieved the pain of sick and wounded soldiers by prescribing millions of doses of a highly addictive medication called **morphine**. Morphine worked well to ease wounded soldiers' pain, but many Civil War **veterans**, or people who had served in the military, became addicted to it.

The war had direct economic consequences for American families. The loss of fathers or sons often meant the loss of family breadwinners. Countless wounded veterans were unable to work, and families fell into poverty. Many homes, farms,

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CRITICAL VIEWING To commemorate the centennial anniversary of the end of the Civil War, the National Geographic Society commissioned Tom Lovell to paint *Surrender at Appomattox*. Lee, dressed in gray, signs the surrender terms while Grant and his officers look on. Their meeting was somber, but friendly. Upon signing, Lee is reported to have said, "This will have a very happy effect on my army." Based on details you notice in the painting, how did Grant treat Lee during the signing?

and businesses, particularly in the South, had been destroyed. Lives, careers, and communities had to be rebuilt.

Even after financial costs were recovered, the emotional toll of such intense loss persisted for generations. The war itself became the subject or backdrop for art and literature. In 1862, Louisa May Alcott served as a nurse in Washington, D.C., during the war. She was sent home when she contracted a serious disease called typhoid from the unsanitary conditions in the hospital. In 1863, Alcott published *Hospital Sketches*, a collection of stories crafted from her letters home about her hospital experiences. Thirty-two years later Stephen Crane published *The Red Badge of Courage*, a novel based on the life of Private Henry Fleming. Crane was not yet born when the war broke out, but his novel captured the horrific details of battlefield experiences nonetheless. That Crane's novel still resonated with American readers three decades after the war ended speaks to the profound effect the Civil War had on the country.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What were the terms of surrender that Grant delivered to Lee?
2. **ANALYZE LANGUAGE USE** What do you think Grant was saying about what it means to be an American when he stated, "The war is over. The Rebels are our countrymen again"?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Explain whether you think the financial losses or personal losses of the war were greater, and support your opinion with information from the text.

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